Playing with Fire

By Tess Gerritsen

(Pg 199-200) May 1944 -- Late at night, lying in his bunk, Lorenzo could hear the screams from Cell No. 1. He never knew who was being tortured. He never saw the victims. He only knew that from night to night, the voices of the tormented kept changing. Sometimes a woman's shrieks, sometimes a man's. Sometimes a baritone voice would crack into the girlish sobs of a boy still on the threshold of manhood. He had been warned by the Italian Colonel: ***See nothing. Hear nothing. Say nothing. And you just might survive.***

INTRODUCTION

Lorenzo Todesco is a young Jewish violinist in 1940s Italy. Jews had lived in Italy for over two thousand years. In fact, the Italian Jewish community was one of the oldest in Europe. But this is Mussolini's Italy, and a brutal war is on. And although more than 40,000 Jews survived the Holocaust in Italy, the Todesco family were not among the survivors. For a time, Lorenzo Todesco was one of the lucky ones. Hand-picked for his musical prowess, Lorenzo was forced with five others to play his composition ***Incendio*** *(The Fire) over and over. In this selection he recounts one horrific day*

4NG Fanatics

among many, playing his role in the "orchestra of the damned."

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(Pg 185) When you cannot see where you are going, when you do not know your final destination, every hour is its own eternity. **(Pg 200-205)** Most human beings can learn to endure almost anything, even the cries of the tormented. It was not that their hearts had hardened; it was because they could do nothing about it, and powerlessness leads to its own form of serenity.

Did he dream of the platform where they had all been singled out as musicians and ripped from those they loved? Even now, months later, the wound left by that separation felt as painful to Lorenzo as a fresh amputation. While their families had almost certainly perished, music had kept alive this ensemble of six broken men. Each handpicked by the Italian Colonel. There was Shlomo, the drummer from Milan, who'd been arrested with his family as they'd tried to cross the border into Switzerland. There was Emilio, the second violinist, who'd been dragged from a friend's farmhouse, a friend who had been summarily executed for hiding a Jew. There was Vittorio, the cellist, arrested in

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Vincenza, whose hair had magically turned white within weeks of arriving at San Sabba. There was Carlo, the French horn player who had once been fat, and whose loose skin now flopped in pale drapes. And finally there was Aleks, the viola player, a musician so talented he could have found a position with any symphony in the world. Instead here he was, a mere husk of a man who performed with mechanical fingers and empty eyes.

In Cell No. 1, the screams rose to a shriek so piercing that Lorenzo clapped his hands over his ears, desperate to shut out the sound. He pressed them there until the screams faded and all he could hear was the whoosh of his own pulse. When at last he dared to pull his hands away from his ears, he heard the squeal of the cell door and the scrape of the prisoner's body being dragged out to the courtyard. He knew its final destination.

Three months ago, construction had begun in the building across from their cell block. Though he'd been advised to see nothing, hear nothing, Lorenzo could hardly be blind to all the trucks hauling materials through the gate and into the compound. At first none of the musicians knew what was being built. Lorenzo assumed they were

4NG Fanatics

adding another cell block to house the flood of new detainees. Every week, so many men, women and children arrived by train that they were sometimes herded into an open courtyard and spent days shivering and exposed, waiting to be transported north. Yes, a new cell block made sense.

Then he began to hear whispers from the prisoners; they had seen an underground tunnel leading to the chimney stack. No, this was not some new cell block being built. It was something else. One cold morning in April, Lorenzo saw smoke curl from that chimney for the first time. That chimney billowed a singular stench that could not be escaped. It clung to clothes and hair, swirled up throats and noses, and was inhaled into lungs. Both prisoners and guards alike were forced to breathe in the dead.

See nothing. Hear nothing. Say nothing. This is how you survive.

Everyone closed their ears to the screams from Cell No. 1 and to the executioner's gunshots beyond the walls of the compound. But there was one sound no one could shut out, a sound so horrifying that even the guards would

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grimace. Some of the executed prisoners delivered to the ovens were not really dead, but merely stunned by what should have been a fatal bullet or blow, and they were thrown into the flames alive.

To drown out the noise of the dying, San Sabba's little orchestra of the damned was ordered to play music in the courtyard. Since dawn, round after round of gunshots had been booming outside the walls. Now the first truck rolled in, weighed down with the harvest from that morning's gunfire. "More logs for the fire," the Italian colonel announced. "Well, what are you waiting for? Begin!"

They did not choose sedate minuets or quiet airs, for the purpose of this music was not to entertain. It was to disguise and distract, and for that they needed music played at maximum volume. The Italian Colonel paced the courtyard as they performed, haranguing his musicians to play louder! Louder!

But it was not loud enough. It could never be loud enough to hide the horrors inside the building with the smokestack.

The first truck pulled away; a second one rolled through the gates, so overloaded that it sagged low on its axles. As

4NG Fanatics

it bounced across the courtyard, part of its cargo tumbled out through the open canvas flap and landed with a sickening thud on the stones.

Lorenzo stared down at the man's caved-in skull, the naked limbs, the wasted flesh. ***More logs for the fire.*** Lorenzo's bow trembled and his notes slid out of tune as his fingers went numb with the horror of what lay at his feet.

COLONEL: Play! I order you, play! Forte, forte, forte!

Lorenzo dug his bow harder into the strings and tried to stay focused on his music stand, but the corpse was staring up at him, and Lorenzo could see the eyes were green.

Two soldiers jumped out of the truck to retrieve their lost bit of cargo. One of the soldiers tossed down the stub of the cigarette he'd been smoking, crushed it with his boot, and bent down to grasp the dead man's ankles. His partner grasped the wrists and together they swung the corpse back into the truck, as casually as if they were tossing a sack of flour. For them, a dead body tumbling from their vehicle was not even worth a pause in their conversation. And why would it be, when there wer so many trucks like their rumbling in, day after day, each with the same terrible cargo? The butcher who hacks and saws

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away at countless carcasses does not think of sweet-faced lambs; he sees only meat. Just as the soldiers delivering their daily load of corpses saw only fresh fuel for the incinerator.

And through it all, the orchestra kept playing. Through the roar of the truck and the backing of dogs and the staccato of distant gunfire. Through the screams inside the oven. Most important, the screams. They played until those screams at last faded, until the trucks rumbled away empty and foul-smelling smoke billowed from the chimney. They played so they would not have to listen or think or feel, focusing on the music and only the music. Don't concern yourselves with what's happening in that building. Just keep your eyes on the notes, your bow on the strings.

(Pg 207) What was earlier a frantic melody has slowed to the ponderous chords of a funeral dirge. **(Pg 208)** A waltz . . . for the dying. **(Pg 207)** There is no dramatic flourish at the end, no dazzling final run. There are just three final notes, muted and mournful, which fade into silence. **(Pg 215)** For thousands of condemned prisoners who were marched to their executions, that waltz – ***Incendio***, (The Fire) was the last music they heard. A waltz to die by.

4NG Fanatics

(Pg 205) And when the day's ordeal was over, when they were finally given leave to stop playing, they were too exhausted to rise from their chairs. **(Pg 200)** [You see,] most human beings can learn to endure almost anything, even the cries of the tormented. It was not that their hearts had hardened; it was because they could do nothing about it, and powerlessness leads to its own form of serenity.

(Pg 205) They sat with instruments lowered, heads bowed, until the guards prodded them to their feet. Then back to their cell they marched in silence. Their instruments had already spoken for them, and there was nothing left to say. *(long beat)*

(Pg 215) In October of 1944, Lorenzo Todesco and his fellow musicians were marched to their own executions. Their bodies were fed to the oven.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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For additional historical information regarding The Holocaust in Italy and the San Sabba Police Camp in Trieste:

https://encyclopedia.ushmm.org/content/en/article/italy

https://www.holocausthistoricalsociety.org.uk/contents/aktionreinhardt/sansabba.html

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